BOARD INFINITY

# Group Discussion

# Things we will cover

1. Understanding the **evaluation process**
2. How to **conduct the GD**
3. **Different GDs-** Role-specific & Topic Specific
4. **Framework for developing compelling points** with data/examples
5. **Managing chaotic GD** dynamics - Making smooth entries, moderating discussions
6. How to **handle difficult situations** e.g. not having points in the discussion, handling multiple interjections etc.
7. **Quality vs quantity of entries** - Finding the right balance
8. How to **improve an individual's chances** of selection
9. Focus on a **demo GD** within the session (10-12 students panel)

# Understanding the Evaluation Process for GD

**Objective of GD Evaluation**

- To assess communication skills
- To gauge subject knowledge
- To evaluate teamwork and leadership abilities
- To measure critical thinking and problem-solving skills

**Key Evaluation Criteria**

- Clarity and Articulation
- Content and Relevance
- Listening Skills
- Conduct and Etiquette

# How to conduct the Group Discussion

## Utilizing the initial few mins to prepare

| Common Guidelines | Do's | Don'ts |
|---|---|---|
| ● Start by understanding the Topic<br>● Note 2-3 core themes or arguments<br>● Think of pros, cons, examples, counter-arguments, etc.<br>● Note Down Data and Examples<br>● Consider Different Perspective<br>● you want to focus on along with supporting data/examples<br>● Identify 1-2 critical gaps in the topic where you can provide an alternative perspective<br>● Craft an opening statement that provides context, establishes your position and transitions smoothly | ● Keep your notes organized; use bullet points or numbering.<br>● Aim for clarity; your notes should be easily readable in a glance.<br>● Be concise; use keywords or short phrases instead of complete sentences.<br>● Anticipate potential opposing views<br>● Make note of relevant vocabulary, buzzwords, acronyms, names, data points that add credibility<br>● Prepare analogies, stories, anecdotes to make your points memorable and impactful | ● Don't spend too much time pondering a single point.<br>● Don't write down overly complex points that are hard to articulate quickly.<br>● Don't ignore opposing viewpoints; be prepared for a balanced discussion. |

# How to conduct the Group Discussion

## Common Frameworks to use

| Causes and Effects | Feasibility and Outcomes |
|---|---|
| **Impact of Social Media on Mental Health**<br><br>Causes:<br>● Comparison: Constant exposure to idealized lives.<br>● Cyberbullying: Increased incidents of online harassment.<br>● FOMO: Fear of Missing Out due to constant updates.<br>Effects:<br>● Anxiety: Constant need for validation through likes and comments.<br>● Depression: Negative self-image due to comparison.<br>● Addiction: Over-dependence on social media for emotional needs.<br>Additional Points:<br>● Real-world Examples: Studies linking social media usage to mental health issues.<br>● Solutions: Digital detox, regulations on content.l | **Universal Basic Income - A Sustainable Solution?**<br><br>Feasibility:<br>● Funding: How will it be funded? Taxation, reallocation of welfare funds.<br>● Implementation: Logistics, eligibility criteria.<br>Outcomes:<br>● Poverty Reduction: Direct financial support.<br>● Job Flexibility: Freedom to pursue meaningful work.<br>● Inflation: Risk of driving up prices.<br>Additional Points:<br>● Case Studies: Pilot programs in Finland, Canada.<br>● Ethical Considerations: Fairness, work ethic. |

# How to conduct the Group Discussion

## Common Frameworks to use

| Features Comparison | Pros and Cons |
| --- | --- |
| **Electric Cars Vs Traditional Cars**<br><br>Electric Cars:<br>● Eco-Friendly: Zero emissions.<br>● Low Operating Costs: Cheaper to run and maintain.<br>● Quiet: Reduced noise pollution.<br>Traditional Cars:<br>● Range: Longer driving range without refueling.<br>● Infrastructure: Established network of fueling stations.<br>● Upfront Cost: Generally cheaper than electric cars.<br>Additional Points:<br>● Future Trends: Governments pushing for electric vehicles.<br>● Counter-arguments: Battery disposal issues in electric cars. | **Should Work from Home Become a Permanent Option?**<br><br>Pros:<br>● Cost Savings: Reduced commute and office expenses.<br>● Work-Life Balance: Flexibility to manage personal commitments.<br>● Global Talent Pool: Opportunity to hire from anywhere.<br>Cons:<br>● Isolation: Lack of social interaction with teammates.<br>● Productivity: Potential distractions at home.<br>● Team Cohesion: Reduced face-to-face communication can impact teamwork.<br>Additional Points:<br>● Examples: Tech companies like Twitter allowing permanent WFH.<br>● Counter-arguments: Not all roles are suitable for WFH, e.g., manufacturing |

# How to conduct the Group Discussion

## Common Frameworks to use

| Short-term vs Long-term Effects | Context and Interpretation |
| --- | --- |
| **Can Money Buy Happiness?**<br><br>**Short-term Effects:**<br><br>● Immediate Gratification: Luxuries, vacations.<br>● Stress Relief: Financial security can reduce stress.<br><br>**Long-term Effects:**<br><br>● Diminishing Returns: The happiness derived from money can decrease over time.<br>● Emotional Well-being: Money can't replace relationships or emotional fulfillment.<br>**Additional Points:**<br>● Cultural Perspectives: How different cultures view the relationship between money and happiness.<br>● Philosophical Angles: What is the true meaning of happiness? | **Is Silence Really Golden?**<br><br>Personal: Silence as a form of introspection.<br>Social: Silence as consent or dissent in social issues.<br>Interpretation:<br><br>Positive: Silence as a form of strength and maturity.<br>Negative: Silence as a form of ignorance or avoidance.<br>Additional Points:<br>Real-world Applications: How silence is used effectively in diplomacy, therapy, etc.<br>Ethical Questions: When is it unethical to remain silent? |

# How to conduct the Group Discussion

## Initiating the Discussion

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Opening Statement** | Personal Stance: Clearly state your own stance on the topic without elaborating too much. | "I believe that renewable energy is not just an option but a necessity for a sustainable future." |
| **Ask Open-ended Question** | Pose an open-ended question to the group to kickstart the discussion | "What are your thoughts on the feasibility of shifting entirely to renewable energy sources?" |
| **Inviting Participation** | Prompt for Diverse Opinions: Encourage participants to bring in various perspectives. | "I'd love to hear different viewpoints on this, perhaps starting with the economic implications." |
| **Set the Tone** | Respectful Discourse: Remind everyone to maintain decorum and respect differing opinions. | "Let's aim for a constructive discussion where we respect each other's viewpoints." |
| **Definitions and Clarifications** | Define Key Terms: Briefly define any jargons or key terms related to the topic. | "When we talk about 'sustainability,' we are referring to long-term ecological balance." |
| **Scope of Discussion** | Clarify what the GD will cover and what it won't. | "For the purpose of this discussion, we will focus on renewable energy as a solution to climate change, rather than debating the existence of climate change itself." |

# How to conduct the Group Discussion

## Initiating the Discussion

| Common Guidelines | Do’s | Don'ts |
|---|---|---|
| ● Start by briefly summarizing the topic to set context.<br>● Use open-ended questions to kickstart the discussion. | ● Be clear and concise.<br>● Use a moderate tone to invite others into the discussion.<br>● Provide a brief opening statement setting context<br>● Establish ground rules like raise hand, time limits | ● Start abruptly without consensus<br>● Dive right into content without introduction<br>● Begin without allowing others time to think<br>● Don't dominate the conversation from the start.<br>● Don't start with a controversial point that might polarize the group. |

# How to conduct the Group Discussion

## Progressing the Discussion

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Acknowledge Points | Acknowledge the points made by previous speakers before adding your own. | “I understand where you're coming from about the economic implications, but have we considered the social aspects?" |
| Building On Points | Extend or elaborate on points already made. | "Adding to what was just mentioned about economic benefits, renewable energy also creates new job opportunities." |
| Contradictions and Rebuttals | If you disagree with a point, express your contrary opinion respectfully. | "I see your point, but there is evidence to suggest otherwise." |
| Support with Facts | Always back your counter-arguments with data or credible sources. | "According to a study by XYZ, renewable energy can actually reduce electricity costs." |
| Introduce New Angles | If the discussion is becoming one-dimensional, introduce a new angle or sub-topic. | "We've talked a lot about the economic aspects; what about the environmental impact?" |
| Moderate and Redirect | If the discussion starts going off-topic, gently steer it back. | "I think we've strayed a bit from the original topic. Can we get back to discussing the pros and cons of renewable energy?" |
| Invite Quiet Members | Encourage quieter members to participate. | "We haven't heard from some of you yet. Any thoughts on the environmental benefits?” |

# How to conduct the Group Discussion

## Progressing the Discussion

| Common Guidelines | Do's | Don'ts |
|---|---|---|
| • Build on points made by others.<br>• Use transition phrases like "Adding to that," "On the other hand," etc., to smoothly progress the discussion. | • Be respectful while disagreeing.<br>• Actively listen and respond to others' points.<br>• Offer new perspectives and data/examples to add value<br>• Moderate politely to keep discussion focused | • Don't over-interrupt others mid-sentence.<br>• Don't go off-topic or introduce irrelevant points.<br>• Make repetitive points lacking depth |

# How to conduct the Group Discussion

## Closing/ Summarizing the Discussion

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Main Points Recap | Summarize the key points that have been discussed during the GD. | "We've explored various dimensions of this topic, from its economic implications to its social impact." |
| Acknowledgment of Diverse Views | Acknowledge that the topic has multiple perspectives and that many have been covered. | "It's evident that there are strong arguments on both sides." |
| Your Final Stance | Clearly state your concluding thoughts or stance on the topic. | "After hearing all viewpoints, I remain convinced that renewable energy is our best path forward." |
| Justification | Briefly justify your final stance based on the discussion. | "The environmental and economic benefits discussed today reinforce this belief." |
| Common Ground | If the group reached a consensus, highlight it. | "It seems we all agree that renewable energy has significant long-term benefits." |
| Acknowledgment of Dissent | If no consensus was reached, acknowledge the diversity of thought. | "While we may not all agree, it's clear that this is a complex issue with no easy answers." |
| Thank Participants | Thank everyone for their contributions to the discussion. | “Thank you all for a stimulating and insightful discussion” |

# How to conduct the Group Discussion

## Closing/ Summarizing the Discussion

| Common Guidelines | Do’s | Don'ts |
|---|---|---|
| • Summarize key points that have been discussed.<br>• Seek consensus or note differing viewpoints, as applicable. | • Acknowledge others' contributions<br>• End with a strong, memorable point or statement. | • End abruptly without wrapping up<br>• Don't introduce new points in the closing stage.<br>• Don't close the discussion abruptly without summarizing. |

# Framework for developing compelling points with data/examples

## P.R.E.P. Framework

- P: Point (State your main argument or point clearly and concisely.)
- R: Reason (Provide a reason for your point. Why is this point important? What does it signify or imply?)
- E: Evidence (Data/Examples) (Offer supporting evidence in the form of data, statistics, or examples.)
- P: Point (Reiteration) (Conclude by reiterating your initial point, summarizing how the reason and evidence support it.)

**Examples**

- Point: "I believe that online education democratizes access to quality education."
- Reason: "It's important because not everyone has the means or the opportunity to attend traditional educational institutions, which often require physical presence and are more expensive."
- Evidence:
    - Data: "According to a study by Harvard University, online courses have enabled 12 million people to access higher education who wouldn't have otherwise.
    - Example: "Platforms like Coursera and Udemy offer courses from top universities and experts in the field, making it accessible to someone sitting in a remote village with internet access.
- Point (Reiteration): "So, as the data and examples suggest, online education indeed democratizes access to quality education, breaking down both geographical and financial barriers."

# Framework for developing compelling points with data/examples

**P.E.E.L. Framework (Useful For: Making a single, in-depth point)**

- P: Point
- E: Explanation
- E: Evidence
- L: Link back to the question/topic

**P (Point):** "I believe that social media has a profound impact on mental health."
**E (Explanation):** "The constant exposure to idealized representations of other people's lives can lead to feelings of inadequacy and low self-esteem."
**E (Evidence):** Data: "A study by the Royal Society for Public Health in the UK found that 70% of young people surveyed felt that their mental health was adversely affected by social media."
Example: "Popular platforms like Instagram, where users often post only the highlights of their lives, can create a false sense of inadequacy among viewers."
**L (Link back to the question/topic):** "Therefore, the impact of social media on society extends to significant mental health concerns, particularly among the youth."

# Framework for developing compelling points with data/examples

**S.T.A.R. Framework (Useful For: Case-based discussions, situational analysis)**

- S: Situation
- T: Task
- A: Action
- R: Result

"In many tech companies, employee turnover is a significant issue, often exceeding 20% annually." **"The task is not just to keep employees but to keep them engaged and productive."** "One effective action could be the implementation of a robust career development program. This can include mentorship, training, and clear paths to career progression." ***"As a result of such programs, companies like Google have seen a significant decrease in turnover, down to around 10%."***

# How to handle Chaotic GD (Fish Market situation)

- **Remain calm** and composed. Don't get flustered or lose confidence.
- **Listen carefully to find openings** to enter the discussion. Identify gaps in arguments you can fill.
- Use **polite interjections** like "Excuse me, could I add something here?" or “If I may add a crucial point here," or "I think we're overlooking something important." to make smooth entries.
- **Build on points made by others** before segueing into your view. Find common ground.
- **Keep responses crisp** and structured. The less time you take, the less chance you'll be interrupted. Avoid long monologues.
- Request moderation if things get out of hand. **Suggest taking turns.**
- **Be Loud Enough**: Your voice needs to rise above the chaos, but without shouting. Use a clear, strong voice to ensure you are heard.
- **Adapt speaking pace and tone** for the room. Project confidence.
- **Use Non-Verbal Cues**: Use hand gestures to indicate you want to speak, make eye contact with other participants, nod to show you are engaged.

# Tips to Handle Lack of Subject Knowledge in GD

- Listen Attentively: Listening can help you gather valuable insights about the topic.
- Leverage General Knowledge: Try to relate the topic to something you know. Use analogies to make points.
- Offer alternative perspectives - Risks, stakeholder impacts, ethics - to add value.
- Ask Clarifying Questions: Asking questions can buy you time and also provide you with valuable information.
- Build on Others' Points: Adding to what someone else has said can be a good strategy when you don't know much about the topic.
- Be Concise: When you don't know much, it's better to make fewer, concise points to minimize the chance of making errors.
- Exhibit Positive Body Language: Positive body language can help you appear more confident and engaged.
- Try to Summarize the discussion
- Identify aspects of the topic that align with your expertise. Guide discussion towards those.
- Suggest frameworks to structure the analysis - SWOT, Porter's 5 forces etc.

# Closing Remarks: Tips to Improve Your Chances of Selection

- **Know Your Objective :** Understand what the panel is looking for: Communication skills, Teamwork, Knowledge, etc.
- **Preparation Strategies**
  - Research Common Topic: Current Affairs, Industry Trends, Ethical Dilemmas
  - Practice with Mock GDs: Helps you get used to the format and timing
- **During the GD**
  - Make a Strong Opening
  - Be an Active Listener
  - Support Points with Data
  - Be Mindful of Body Language
- **Navigating Challenges**
  - How to Handle Chaos: Sub-Bullet: Stay calm, wait for openings, use non-verbal cues
  - When You Lack Subject Knowledge: Sub-Bullet: Listen carefully, ask clarifying questions, build on others' points
- **Closing Strong**
  - Summarize Key Points
  - End with a Thought-Provoking Statement or Question
- **Common Pitfalls to Avoid**
  - Dominating the Conversation
  - Being too Passive
  - Going Off-Topic

# Topics for Mock GD

- The Impact of Cryptocurrency on Global Economy
- You are the management team of a failing airline. What steps would you take to revive it?
- Is Time Travel Possible?
- Is it Ethical to Use Animals for Testing Medicines?
- The Future of Renewable Energy in India
- The Role of Social Media in Mental Health